east Afghanistan, where he commands authority, are areas where India has invested heavily, both overtly using the SDPs and other projects, and covertly in the security sector.

This is indicative in India's strong links with the current chief of Kandahar Police and a big power broker in the southern province, General Abdul Razzik. A close ally of Karzai, Razzik received tremendous support from the US, and has been on the Taliban's hit list for many years.[81] However, he is a controversial figure, involvement in drug trafficking, and accused of mass murder. In February 2010 (soon after the London conference where reconciliation with the Taliban was given primacy), US officials challenged Razzik to disclose the source of such staggeringly high levels of wealth that he had accumulated over the years. Smiling wryly, Razzik informed said officials that part of his wealth came from his two brothers who worked in Dubai and India. Though he had visited Dubai, he had never set foot in India.[82] Though impressed by Razzik's confidence, the US ambassador to Kabul, Karl Eikenberry, had 'no illusions about his [Razzik] corrupt activities'. Eikenberry was certain that Razzik's brothers were laundering his illicit wealth via Dubai and India, without New Delhi doing much about it. Many such relationships (including with Gul Agha Sherzai in Nangarhar, whom Razzik knew well) would ensure India's presence in Afghanistan's southern and eastern provinces.

Karzai's political dexterity appealed both to India's sense of regional ambitions and India's insecurities. Shyam Saran agrees that India developed 'fairly strong constituencies among the Pashtuns ... and one of the reasons is that we have very good relations with Karzai [who] is a Pashtun, and ten years ago when this whole exercise began, he was regarded as pro-Pakistan. He was put there because the Pakistanis were comfortable with having him as the head of the government [but] the situation changed over time.'[83] The curious aspect about the 'Najibullah Model' was that it failed when support from Moscow dried up in 1992. And so did India's partisan approach towards Afghanistan (when it failed to secure Najibullah's escape). Karzai's reluctance to sign the BSA with the US then put a big question mark on the efficacy of another Najibullah type ally in Afghanistan. Shashank, India's foreign secretary in 2003–04, argued that the slow shift in India's position towards Karzai, was mostly a signal to different Afghan factions